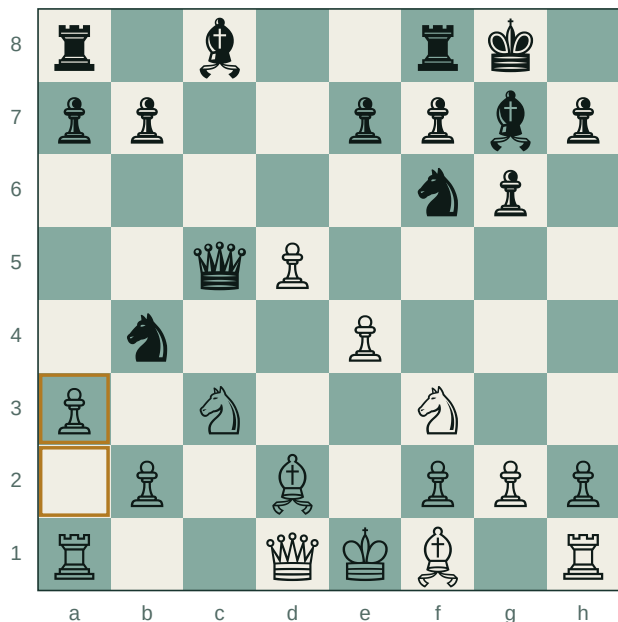


Calculated sacrifices: Black, move 11

Calculated sacrifices

Black to move



Previous move: 11.a3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

11...Nxe4 12. Nxe4 Nc2+ 13. Qxc2 Qxc2

11...Nxe4 The knight captures the pawn on e4. From e4 it attacks knight on c3 and bishop on d2. Recorded reply: **12.Nxe4**.

12...Nc2+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. From c2 it attacks king on e1 and rook on a1. Recorded reply: **13.Qxc2**.

13...Qxc2 The queen captures the queen on c2. From c2 it attacks knight on e4 and bishop on d2.

At the end, nominal material is White 28 / Black 31 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +4. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +4:** the balance goes from -1 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attractive attacking picture is not compensation by itself. Continue until the resulting position can be evaluated honestly.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A sacrifice exchanges material for a concrete benefit. The benefit may be mate, a stronger attack, a recovered investment, or lasting activity; it must be shown through moves.

HOW TO LOOK

State what the sacrifice changes: a defender, a line, a king square, or a critical tempo. Calculate acceptance and plausible refusal.

The defending king is on e1. Geometrically undefended: rook on h1. Check for tactical protection.